

something more worthy that you should have spent the money on, but you can train yourself to treat this money differently, and it can make a real difference in the pursuit of that sense of money neutrality, i.e. being able to sever the connection between your finances and your self-worth and treat money as a tool.

This idea of a bank of savings just for enjoyment, or a 'slush fund' as he called it, was suggested to me in a call with Dr Ash Ranpura, a neuroscientist that I was working with on a campaign. He suggested that any unexpected, trivial or gifted amounts of money were used to fund this pot – Christmas or birthday money, say, or cashback on purchases or refunds for things like late trains. We all know how quickly these small amounts of money disappear in the wilds of our current accounts, but in diverting them to a slush fund, we give them a purpose and ourselves a way of spending money on ourselves without feeling guilty.

True self-care is not for sale

How did we allow looking after ourselves to become so commodified? At what point did the act of trying to feel okay, trying to feel *well*, go up for sale? These are questions that I ask myself on a regular basis, a provocation that I use to refocus my brain when it starts to look for commercial self-care solutions. Having spent my teenage years as a disciple of advertising slogans telling me that I deserved a certain product, that I was